Appendix D

The multi-element model of behaviour change

In school and other care environments, the carer and child or young person naturally develop a relationship which impacts on how situations may be managed. In many cases, there will be a care plan compiled by the professionals responsible for their wellbeing of the child or young person which will assist in assessing and managing risk. It is helpful if this care plan addresses all the elements of a multi-element plan.

The multi-element model was originally proposed by a team of psychologists working in the US1. The model is based on an understanding that all behaviour communicates a message and attempts to meet needs. This assumption applies even when young people are not deliberately trying to communicate messages, or when they are unaware of the messages that they are communicating. The model goes on to say that difficulties often arise because some children and young people choose unhelpful, or inappropriate ways to communicate their messages or to get their needs met.

It follows from this that any attempt to modify "problem" behaviour must first understand the message or purpose of the young person's behaviour. The intervention is then designed to help the young person find alternative ways to either achieve the same purpose or to tolerate the fact that his or her immediate needs cannot be met. This type of intervention plan is qualitatively different from one that simply seeks to "eliminate problem behaviour". Proponents of the multi-element plan believe that if a person's needs and messages are simply ignored, this can lead to increased frustration and behaviour difficulties. Alternatively, and of equal concern, it might lead to the young person withdrawing from the world around them, based on a mistaken belief that those around the young person do not care, or are unable to meet their needs. It is hard to help someone learn when they have this kind of belief!

It is important to keep accurate records of when incidents of challenging behaviour do and do not occur. This will help identify consistent patterns and therefore consistent messages. For example, if challenges were often shown in busy environments, but rarely in quiet times, then it would be reasonable to assume that the child or young person is communicating, "I need some space to myself."

Sometimes, when we are seeking to understand behaviour, we go back to past-focused explanations such as "It is because she was abused when she was younger" or "He does that because that's how his family has always behaved." These explanations may be true, but they will rarely lead to any positive change for the young person. Instead, it is important to try to reach for present-focused explanations that answer the question, "What current goal is this child trying to achieve? What problem is he/she trying to solve?"

It is often helpful to use these behaviour records to form hypotheses about what the child or young person might say to you if:

- They were very self-aware, and able to recognise what was driving their behaviour.
- They had very good communication skills and were able to express their feelings and needs in words.
- They were very self-confident and able to acknowledge their feelings and needs to another person.

1 See, for example, LaVigna, G.W. & Willis, T.J. (1995) "Challenging Behaviour: A model for breaking the barriers to social and community integration" Positive Practices: The IABA newsletter 1, 1, 8 – 15 or

LaVigna, G.W. & Willis, T.J. (2005) A Positive Behavioural Support Model for Breaking the Barriers to Social and Community Inclusion Learning Disability Review, 10, 16 – 23

Of course, for many young people whose behaviour leads to challenge, one of the very reasons why their behaviour causes difficulties is precisely because they have not yet developed enough self-awareness, communication skill or self-confidence! So the adult needs to use the records to help develop some hypotheses, and wonder how the young person might complete sentences like, "I want....", "I need....", "I wish....", "I hate...."

The multi-element model suggests that there should be two main groups of approaches, built upon this understanding of the message value of the young person's behaviour. The first group are proactive approaches, which are designed to influence the future, by helping the young person learn new behaviours. The second group is composed of responsive strategies, designed to manage any present incidents of difficulty. Proponents of the multi-element model believe that a well-balanced intervention must include both proactive and responsive strategies.

There are three sets of approaches within the proactive group. Environmental changes involve adaptations to the young person's environment so that it better matches their needs. For example, a boy whose behaviour communicates that he finds the classroom stressful when there is too much "going on around him" might be given his own workstation. Another girl who always finds herself in trouble for pushing and hurting other children in the playground might be allowed to choose one child to play a special game in a restricted area under the supervision of an older school prefect.

However, it is also important to help children learn new skills, so that they can learn to behave appropriately in situations where the world has not been adapted to their specific needs. A second section of the proactive group is called teaching new skills. This section describes approaches and materials that will be used to help the young person find alternative ways of communicating their needs, or of tolerating that their needs cannot be met immediately. The girl who was in trouble at break times might be taught firstly how to play some simple playground games and secondly how to approach children and invite them to play. (This type of intervention would be based on an assumption that her "problem behaviour" was actually an attempt to say, "I'd like to play with you").

The third proactive approach is reinforcement. This is based on an understanding that it is often harder to learn and demonstrate new behaviours than it is to go back to old habits. A well designed intervention will consider the payoffs for the young person's current behaviours and then seek to make it more rewarding for the young person to put effort into demonstrating the new skills identified in the teaching new skills section.

Responsive strategies describe the agreed ways of responding to the challenging behaviours when they occur in order to prevent a difficult situation getting worse. In the pure multi-element model, these are entirely non-aversive. In other words, they are not punitive. However, in many school situations, a calmly delivered consequence may have the effect of helping re-direct a young person back to the desired behaviour pattern. In other situations, and in particular for many of the young people for whom an individual multi-element plan needs to be developed, the responsive strategies will include a range of distraction and diversion tactics. While a child's inappropriate behaviour may have logical consequences, the multi-element model suggests that it may escalate a difficult situation to mention such consequences at the time of a developing crisis. Instead, they would be mentioned and applied once the young person had regained sufficient control.

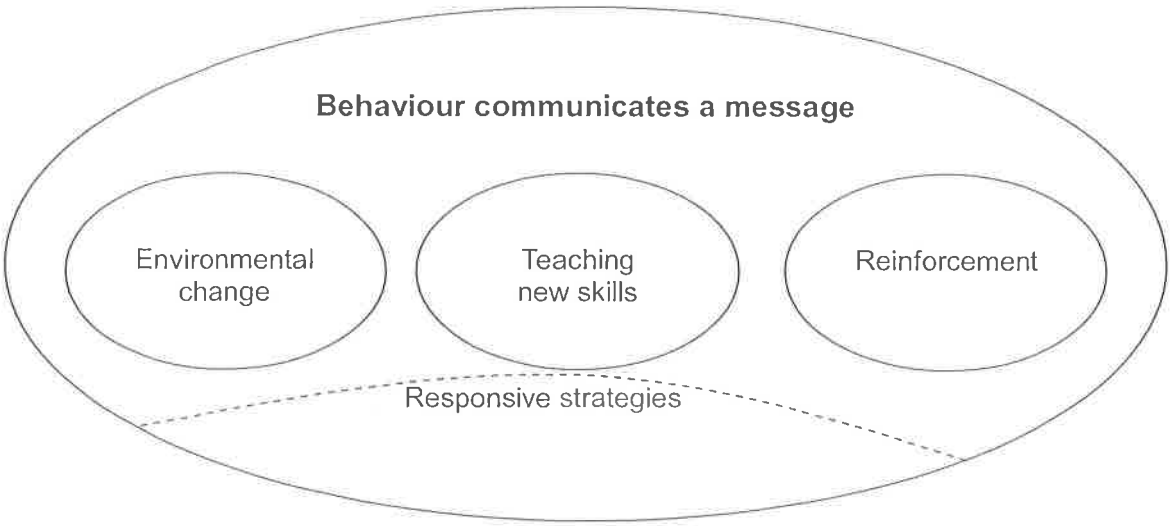
The multi-element plan is a model that needs to be implemented and developed as a whole. This requires assessment and data collection about the situations in which challenging behaviour occurs and does not occur, in order to develop hypotheses about the messages of behaviour. This data collection needs to include a range of perspectives covering different situations at school and at home. And of course, the young person can offer valuable information about what they are trying to achieve!

The multi-element plan can be represented through the picture shown in Figure One below. The model suggests that a comprehensive plan will include:

- An understanding of what the young person is trying to achieve or communicate through his or her behaviour.
- Adaptations to the environment so that it can better meet the young person's needs.

- Approaches that will be used to teach and encourage the young person to use new, more appropriate behaviours, and to cope with difficulties and tensions when his or her needs are not being immediately met.
- Ways to reward the young person when he or she invests effort and engages positively with the plan.
- Planned responses that will be used when the young person's behaviour is challenging.

Figure One



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